

Stephanie and the Riverlight Edict

Official English version using every unique word from the complete deduped flashcard set. A Chinese version follows after the English story.

Chapter 1: The City Under Glass

In the city of Ilyr, rain did not fall from clouds. It was measured out by glass towers, each drop released by order of the Council, each household given enough for bread, tea, and regret. When the summer fever began to **abate**, people spoke in whispers, afraid that gratitude itself might be taxed.

Stephanie Venn worked in the Hall of Lenses, grinding prisms for the water engines. She had an **innate** patience for delicate work and an **insatiable** hunger for forbidden books. Her master said curiosity could **impinge** on obedience, but Stephanie believed obedience had already ruined enough lives.

The first strange sign arrived as an **aberration** in a lens: a thin blue flame bending the wrong way through clear glass. Her master called it dust. Stephanie knew dust did not sing.

Years earlier, Stephanie's **venerable** Grandma Lin and Grandpa Bruce had taught her the **salient** rule of lenses: every beam reveals the hand that blocks it. Grandpa Bruce had a **tenacious** faith in hidden rivers, but his proof was **tenuous**; Grandma Lin had to **truncate** every lesson whenever Council inspectors passed. By **serendipity**, Stephanie still owned one page from his notebook, a diagram with a **scintillating** blue arc. When a **supercilious** inspector dismissed it as childish, she kept it under her mattress until the city's lies reached their **zenith**.

Grace and Ada, Stephanie's best friends, were the only people outside her family who knew she kept the forbidden diagram.

She tried to **ascertain** the cause, but the Hall records had been altered. Whole pages were scraped clean, as if someone had tried to **efface** a century. Stephanie began to **abhor** the smooth official histories with their **banal** praise of the Council's wisdom.

That evening, an **abrasive** knock rattled her door. Stephanie's older sister Melissa slipped inside in an **unkempt** coat before Stephanie could answer.

"Are you Venn's apprentice?" the girl asked.

"That depends on who is asking."

"Melissa Venn, your older sister. I need to **abscond** before the wardens decide to **arraign** me for breathing near a sealed archive."

Melissa spoke with reckless **alacrity**, as if danger were a song she liked. She carried a copper tube full of old maps, a stolen **cache** from beneath the Council House. Stephanie should have summoned the watch. Instead, some **fortuitous** sympathy made her bolt the door.

The maps showed a forgotten river beneath the city. Beside it was a note written in an **austere** hand: *The tower's **hegemony** ends where light bends true.*

"The Council will never **accede** to sharing this," Melissa said. "They will call it **spurious**, then burn it."

Stephanie felt **apprehension** rise, but also a brighter thing. "Then we need proof they cannot burn."

Melissa grinned. "You have **acumen** after all."

Their first ally was Stephanie's older brother Brandon, an **amiable** clerk with a talent for appearing **apathetic** while listening to everything. His family had once been **affluent**, before the Council declared their will a state instrument. He knew the **antecedent** to every modern law and could quote each old decree with miserable accuracy. Brandon and Stephanie shared only sibling shorthand: arguments, loyalty, and the habit of finishing each other's plans.

"The Council's rule is not order," Brandon said. "It is **anarchy** wearing a clean collar."

Stephanie expected Melissa to laugh, but Melissa only nodded. "And the river?"

"An **anomaly** in the foundation surveys. Buried, then hidden."

They agreed to meet beneath the clock market at midnight. Stephanie was not sure she was brave. She was only sure that to **appease** the Council any longer would be to become one of its instruments.

Chapter 2: The Bell House

The route to the river was **circuitous**, dropping through baker tunnels, salt cellars, and an abandoned shrine where old bells lay green with age. Melissa led with a lantern, **deft** on broken stairs. Brandon followed, **diffident** in courage but **assiduous** in carrying the maps.

They found a door sealed with a Council crest. Stephanie's lens made the crest shimmer, and the metal softened.

"That is not ordinary glasswork," Brandon said.

"It is older," Stephanie answered. "Maybe **esoteric**."

Melissa pushed the door. It opened onto a **capacious** cavern where a black river moved without sound.

At the edge waited Stephanie's grandmother, Lin Dain, in a blue coat. "You are late."

Melissa reached for her knife. "And you are?"

"Grandma Lin," Stephanie whispered. "My grandmother."

Grandma Lin lifted her chin. "Once an **eminent** engineer. Now a heretic, according to **edict** seven hundred and nine."

Grandma Lin's manner was **brusque**, but her eyes were **benign**. She had watched the Council **fabricate** shortages for thirty years. The towers did not make water, she said. They withheld it. The river below could nourish every district.

Brandon looked **incredulous**. "Why hide it?"

"Control," Grandma Lin said. "A thirsty city is **tractable**."

Melissa gave a **belligerent** snort. "Then we break the towers."

"You will **balk** at that when you know what it would **entail**." Grandma Lin pointed to the ceiling, where pipes ran like roots. "The towers are **integral** to the city's foundations. Shatter them and half Ilyr sinks."

Their plan had to be **circumspect**, then. They would reveal the river during the Festival of First Rain, when every **dignitary** stood in the open square. Brandon could **corroborate** the old survey records. Stephanie could bend riverlight through the public prism. Melissa could keep the wardens busy.

"A **coup** of truth," Melissa said.

Grandma Lin did not smile. "Truth alone rarely wins. The Council will **bombard** you with accusations. They will **berate**, **castigate**, and threaten your families. They will **debase** the evidence and call your hope **fatuous**."

Stephanie swallowed. "Can we **forestall** them?"

"Perhaps. If you find the Prime Lens."

The Prime Lens had been **bequeathed**, Grandma Lin said, from the city's founders to the first engineers. It could reveal hidden channels by **refraction**. The Council had buried it in the Bell House, a prison for scholars who refused to **capitulate**.

Melissa's face changed. The **bashful** bravado left it. "Mom is in the Bell House. Jimin left a message through the printers."

"Then your rescue and our proof may share a path," Grandma Lin said.

It was an **auspicious** sentence, or a **dire** one. Stephanie could not tell.

Chapter 3: The Prison of Scholars

The Bell House stood at the **confluence** of three canals, windowless and black. Its wardens were **punitive** men who liked rules because rules let them hurt people neatly. To enter, Brandon forged a transfer paper in a hand so **impeccable** that even Grandma Lin whistled.

"Your talent is wasted in records," Melissa told him.

"My talent keeps me alive," Brandon said. "Do not **extol** it too loudly."

They went in disguised as night clerks. The corridors smelled of ink, sweat, and damp stone, an **olfactory** warning that the place had swallowed too many voices. Every step seemed to **reverberate**.

Their guide was Stephanie's mother, Jimin Venn, a **taciturn** prisoner with **pallid** cheeks and eyes like sharpened slate. She had once written a **periodical** mocking the Council's **ostentatious** charity balls. For that **temerity**, she had been made to copy water ledgers until her fingers bled.

"Melissa," Jimin said. "Still reckless, still late."

"Rescue first. Figs later."

Jimin led them through a **tortuous** passage behind the laundry. They passed scholars in cells, some **despondent**, some **zealous**, some so lost in **torpor** that they did not lift their heads. The Council liked to **immure** intelligence where it could not **engender** doubt.

At last they found Stephanie's grandfather, Bruce, in a cell marked *dangerous*. Grandpa Bruce was not dangerous. He was **forlorn**, feverish, and holding a cracked lens.

"You came," he whispered.

"Obviously," Stephanie said, too **coy** to cry.

Grandpa Bruce gave the lens to Stephanie. "Prime. Broken but not dead."

Jimin warned that a patrol was near. The escape became **frenetic**. Melissa struck one warden with a bucket. Brandon, normally **reticent**, recited an **arbitrary** inspection code so confidently that two guards saluted. Stephanie used the Prime shard to blind a third with an **evanescent** flash.

In the yard, alarm bells began a **raucous** clamor. Wardens tried to **assail** them from both sides. Jimin **spurned** the gate path and chose a drainage sluice instead.

"That tunnel is too narrow," Brandon said.

"Then become narrow," Jimin replied.

They crawled through black water, skin scraped, breath thin. By dawn, they emerged in an **arid** cistern beneath the old west district. Grandpa Bruce collapsed, but he was alive.

Stephanie touched Grandpa Bruce's hand with sudden tenderness. "Tell me the Council has a weakness."

Grandpa Bruce gave a **sanguine** smile. "It does. **Hubris**."

Chapter 4: The Festival Scheme

Grandpa Bruce's knowledge was **incontrovertible**. He had seen the hidden ledgers: the Council released scarcity in cycles, a **perpetual** hardship designed to **mitigate** revolt without ending suffering. Too little water created obedience; too much misery created **mutiny**. The Council measured both.

"That is **dastardly**," Brandon said.

"It is also **pragmatic**," Grandpa Bruce answered. "Evil often is."

Grandma Lin listened with **scrupulous** attention while Stephanie repaired the Prime Lens. The work was **strenuous**, each fracture needing alignment to a hair's breadth. Stephanie's hands were **meticulous**, but the lens had a **capricious** shimmer. At times it looked **impervious** to mending; at others, almost eager.

Melissa grew **fractious** during the waiting. She preferred action to patience, **banter** to fear, and once tried to **barter** with Grandma Lin for explosives.

"No," Grandma Lin said.

"I did not say what I was offering."

"Still no."

Brandon discovered that the Festival would **commemorate** the Council's founding with a public blessing. The ceremony required Prince to stand beneath the Great Prism and **expound** on civic **piety**. It was the perfect place to reveal the river.

Yet the risk was **daunting**. If they failed, the Council would **relegate** them to the Bell House or arrange an **ignominious** execution. Prince was **notorious** for turning trials into theater.

"We need more people," Stephanie said.

Jimin knew the **disaffected** printers. Grandpa Bruce knew engineers. Grandma Lin knew old well keepers with **latent** rage. Brandon knew clerks who could **obfuscate** schedules and misplace arrest orders. Their circle widened in **sporadic** meetings and whispered pledges.

It also brought **discord**. Some wanted to expose the truth. Others wanted to **wreak** vengeance. A former soldier proposed a violent **onslaught** on the towers. Stephanie's father, Yamin Venn, a wary **cynic**, argued that citizens preferred lies if lies came with soup.

"You mistake exhaustion for **credulity**," Stephanie told him.

Yamin looked at her with **dour** amusement. "And you mistake courage for a plan."

The criticism stung because it was partly true. Their strategy was **tentative**, their alliances **precarious**, their resources a **paucity** of tools and trust. But the Prime Lens, when whole, cast one clear image on the cavern wall: a **voluminous** underground river, wide enough to save them all.

For the first time, even Yamin was silent.

Chapter 5: Prince

The bad guy Prince, the High Regent, lived in an **opulent** palace of mirrored halls and **ornate** ceilings painted with clouds. His public speeches were **perfunctory**, but his private intelligence was sharp. He had risen from a **marginal** ministry to absolute command because he understood the city's **disposition** better than anyone: fear first, comfort second, memory last.

Prince's chief investigator, Malrec, had an **abrasive** voice and a **fastidious** hatred of disorder. He reported rumors of a repaired lens, missing prisoners, and a **nebulous** group moving through the lower districts.

"Names?" Prince asked.

"A **myriad** of suspects. The most likely is Stephanie Venn, lens apprentice."

"A **fledgling** rebel," Prince said. "How touching."

Malrec added that Melissa Venn had been seen near the Bell House. Prince remembered the Venn family, then Stephanie's grandfather. Stubborn, poor, **obstinate**. Grandpa Bruce had refused to **repudiate** his engineering notes even under punishment.

"Find them," Prince said. "But do not make martyrs."

Malrec bowed. "Shall I **stipulate** quiet capture?"

"No. Make capture seem **fortuitous**. A tax inspection. A curfew mistake. Something **quotidian**."

Prince understood symbols. He also understood how quickly symbols could **ramify**. A single story could spread like smoke, **fomenting** unrest where no army had marched. The upcoming Festival was therefore **imperative**. It had to **exemplify** order.

Still, a faint unease **irked** him. He had spent years building a **tenable** regime, one in which every **requisite** institution depended on his signature. Yet power had its own **malady**: the more he controlled, the more he saw threats everywhere.

He went to the Hall of Measures, where a model of Ilyr glittered under lamps. The towers shone like teeth. Beneath them, unseen by most, the river pulsed in blue thread.

"A city is not family," Prince told Malrec. "It is managed."

Malrec asked, "And if the people **recalcitrantly** refuse management?"

"Then we **rectify** them."

His answer was calm, almost **benign**. That was what made it frightening.

Chapter 6: The Lower Districts

To gather witnesses, Stephanie and Melissa crossed the lower districts, where poverty had become **pervasive** and resentment **incessant**. They met a brewer whose wells had been sealed, a teacher whose schoolchildren fainted during heat rationing, and a nurse who could not **obtain** enough clean water to wash wounds.

Stephanie's best friend Grace, now training as a nurse, was **magnanimous** even in exhaustion. She ran a **philanthropic** clinic with no patron except stubborn decency. Her waiting room was a **morass** of fever, dust, and whispered complaints.

"Can your lens truly reveal water?" Grace asked.

"Yes," Stephanie said.

"Then I will stand with you."

Melissa blinked. "Just like that?"

"Suffering has made some choices simple."

Ada, Stephanie's other best friend, arrived with Zoe, a new friend from the canal quarter. Zoe knew a **loquacious** baker who could not keep secrets but could hide people in flour carts; Ada recruited a **bashful** singer whose voice could carry across the square; Grace found a **punctilious** watchmaker who built timing devices small enough to fit inside prayer beads. Each person added a skill, and with each skill the plan became less **quixotic**.

Yet there were **vicissitudes**. One printer was arrested. A promised wagon broke its axle. A coded notice appeared in the wrong alley and nearly exposed them. Melissa grew **indignant**, then **belligerent**, then quiet.

"You cannot knife every problem," Stephanie told her.

"I can try."

"That is not a strategy."

Melissa gave her a **strident** look. "Neither is polishing glass until Prince politely falls over."

Their quarrel was interrupted by Yamin, Stephanie's father, who arrived with news: Malrec had seized Grandma Lin's workshop.

Stephanie felt the world narrow. "Was she taken?"

"No. She escaped through the roof with the dignity of an angry chimney sweep."

Melissa laughed despite herself. The relief was **exhilarated** and brief.

The raid proved Malrec was close. Their time had become **exigent**. They would move the plan forward by two days, during the rehearsal, when security was thinner.

Brandon called the change **preposterous**. Grandpa Bruce called it **necessary**. Grandma Lin, appearing at dusk with soot on her sleeves, called it "finally interesting."

Chapter 7: The Old Waterworks

The Prime Lens needed one final element: a silver ring from the first tower, now sealed inside the Old Waterworks. The place was considered **infernal**, full of steam vents and collapsed gears. The official histories described it as unsafe, but Grandma Lin said that was an **ostensible** reason. The real reason was that the Waterworks contained founding records.

Inside, the air was hot and tasted of metal. The paths were **tortuous**, some stairways ending over black drops, others looping back in a **circuitous** mockery of progress. Stephanie had to **discern** true passages by the faint **luster** of riverlight on stone.

At the central chamber, they found the ring mounted above a dry fountain. Around it were names of the first engineers, including Grandma Lin's grandmother, the **epitome** of the old guild's **prowess**. Beneath the names was a warning: *Let no **hegemony** claim the common river.*

Brandon copied it with a shaking hand. "This will **vindicate** every banned historian in Ilyr."

"If we survive," Yamin said.

Melissa tried to lift the ring, but the fountain released a cloud of sleep dust. It was nearly **deleterious** enough to drop them all. Stephanie used her scarf as a filter; Grandma Lin opened a vent; Brandon began to **recapitulate** the old maintenance manual from memory because panic made him strange.

"Less lecture, more lever!" Melissa shouted.

They escaped with the ring, but Malrec's men waited outside. The confrontation was **tumultuous**. Stephanie's lens scattered torchlight; Melissa fought with desperate **valor**; Yamin, unexpectedly **adept** with a chain, tripped two wardens into a trough.

Malrec himself stepped forward, **austere** and unhurried. "Give me the ring. I can **remit** half your sentences."

"How generous," Melissa said.

"Generosity is unnecessary. I offer arithmetic."

Stephanie held the ring behind her. "You cannot stop the river."

"No," Malrec said. "But I can stop you."

Then Grandpa Bruce opened a steam valve. White vapor roared through the yard, a **deluge** of heat and noise. The rebels fled into alleys while Malrec's curses faded behind them.

Chapter 8: Trial Without Truth

They did not all escape. Jimin was captured while covering the retreat. By morning, broadsheets announced that Prince would try a traitor at noon, proving the Council's **veracity** before the people.

"They will **fabricate** a confession," Brandon said.

Grandma Lin shook her head. "Jimin will not confess."

"Then they will make silence look like guilt."

The trial took place on the Hall steps. Prince appeared in white, a **paragon** of ceremonial calm. Malrec presented the stolen chain as evidence of a planned **mutiny**. The charges were **spurious**, but the crowd did not know that.

Jimin stood in irons, face bruised, still **reticent**. Prince offered her mercy if she would **concede** that the river maps were false.

Jimin looked at the crowd. "Prince is afraid of water."

A ripple moved through the square.

Prince's smile did not change. "A **fatuous** remark from a woman at her **nadir**."

He ordered a public **reproach**, then a sentence of labor that would surely kill Jimin. The cruelty had a cold **proclivity** toward theater. It was designed not merely to punish but to **stymie** sympathy.

Stephanie watched from a rooftop, hands clenched. To rescue Jimin now would ruin the Festival plan. To wait felt like **acquiescence**.

Melissa saw her struggle. "We cannot save everyone at once."

"That sounds like Prince."

"No. Prince says we should not try."

The distinction was small but **lucid**.

That night, they sent word through the printer network: tomorrow the Great Prism would show the hidden river. Anyone who wanted truth should come to the square with empty cups. The phrase spread in kitchens, clinics, taverns, and shrines. It became a **portent**.

By dawn, the city felt **turbulent**. Even the tower bells seemed unsure of themselves.

Chapter 9: First Rain Rehearsal

The rehearsal began under a **pallid** sky. Prince stood on the central dais while priests prepared an **insipid** blessing and musicians practiced a **perfunctory** anthem. Around the square, citizens gathered with empty cups hidden in sleeves.

Stephanie climbed inside the Great Prism tower. Her task was **onerous**: set the Prime Lens into the mechanism, align the silver ring, and survive long enough for sunlight to strike. She moved with **fastidious** care, every screw a decision.

Below, Brandon **inaugurated** the distraction by announcing a clerical emergency involving three contradictory permits. His performance was **impeccable**. He could make bureaucracy sound like doom.

Melissa and Yamin released dyed smoke near the west gate. The wardens ran toward it, then found themselves trapped in a legal **quandary** as Brandon demanded they sign emergency movement forms. Even Malrec looked **incredulous**.

On the dais, Prince began to speak. "Citizens, the Council has endured **adversity** with you..."

The lie made Stephanie's hands shake. She tightened the ring.

Sunlight struck.

For one breath, nothing happened. Then the Great Prism filled with blue. Light poured across the square, showing a vast river beneath the stones, bright and moving, **infallible** in its simple existence. The image rose over Prince's head like judgment.

The crowd gasped. Cups lifted. Someone began to cry.

Prince tried to **dispel** the vision by ordering the tower shutters closed, but Grandma Lin had jammed them. Malrec shouted for arrests, but the wardens hesitated. The truth was too large to **obfuscate**.

Stephanie's voice carried through the prism horn. "The river is real. The shortages are made."

Prince called her claim **preposterous** and **dastardly**. Grandpa Bruce answered by projecting the founding warning onto the palace wall. Brandon added ledgers showing ration cycles. Grace held up clinic records. The evidence became a **confluence** no single denial could block.

Then Jimin appeared on the Hall steps. Grandma Lin had freed her during the confusion.

The crowd roared.

Chapter 10: Prince's Last Measure

Prince did not **capitulate**. His **disposition** was not surrender but calculation. If truth could not be hidden, it might be drowned. He ordered Malrec to open the emergency gates beneath the square, hoping a sudden flood would make the river seem dangerous.

The plan was **precarious** and cruel. If all gates opened at once, the lower district would be crushed.

Stephanie saw the warning lights flare inside the tower. "He is going to flood us."

Grandma Lin cursed. "We must close the south valves."

That required entering the control pit under the dais. Melissa went first, then Stephanie, Grandpa Bruce, and Yamin. The pit was narrow, loud, and slick. Water hammered the gates with **incessant** force. Each valve was rusted by neglect, **obstinate** as old grief.

"This is beyond us," Yamin said.

Melissa seized a wheel. "That has never been a useful sentence."

They turned. The first valve moved. The second did not. Stephanie wedged the Prime shard into the gear and saw, through **refraction**, the hidden fracture where pressure held it shut.

"There," she said. "Strike there."

Yamin struck. The gear shifted. Water pressure began to **abate**.

Above them, the crowd had become a **morass** of fear and fury. Some called for Prince's death; others begged for order. Grandma Lin used the prism horn to **placate** them, her voice rough but steady. She promised a controlled release, not vengeance.

Malrec found them at the final valve. His sword was drawn. He looked less **austere** now than exhausted.

"You cannot govern what comes next," he told Stephanie.

"Neither can Prince."

"Then there will be **dissolution**."

"Maybe," Stephanie said. "Or a beginning."

Malrec attacked. Melissa **rebuffed** him; Grandpa Bruce stumbled; Yamin was thrown against stone. Stephanie did not fight well, but she knew machines. She opened the last valve.

The river surged into the city channels, not as catastrophe but as release.

Chapter 11: After the Water

By evening, Ilyr had fountains in dry squares and arguments in every street. The Council's authority began to **stagnate**, then crack. Prince was seized by his own guards after trying to flee through a private tunnel. Malrec vanished, perhaps to **abscond**, perhaps to plan **reprisal**.

The provisional assembly was chaotic. People who had been voiceless for years suddenly became **loquacious**. Bakers debated engineers. Nurses corrected priests. Former clerks tried to **reimburse** districts for illegal water fees and discovered that justice was more complicated than sums.

Brandon warned that punishment could become another form of **hegemony**. Melissa wanted the worst officials stripped of rank. Grandma Lin insisted every sentence be **commensurate** with evidence, not rage. Grace proposed **recompense** for families harmed by ration laws. Jimin asked that the Bell House become a school.

Their arguments were **strident**, sometimes **raucous**, often necessary. Stephanie learned that freedom was not peace. It was a **wrangle** with purpose.

Yamin surprised everyone by drafting the first public charter. It was **candid**, practical, and not nearly as **cynical** as he pretended. It would **stipulate** open records, shared wells, and rotating engineers. It would **relegate** emergency powers to short terms and require public review.

"You sound almost hopeful," Stephanie said.

"A **transient** illness."

"You should have Grace examine it."

Yamin smiled, the first truly **congenial** expression she had seen from him.

Yet recovery had a **protracted** cost. The lower canals needed repair. The Bell House prisoners needed care. The city's old **paradigm** had collapsed, and a new one would not be built by speeches. There was **dearth** of trust, **paucity** of tools, and a **surfeit** of grief.

But there was water.

Every morning, children ran to the fountains as if joy were a **perennial** crop. Their laughter had an **ebullient** music that no tower bell could command.

Chapter 12: The Lensmaker's Choice

Months later, Stephanie returned to the Hall of Lenses. It no longer served the Council. Apprentices from every district studied there, including children who once would have been dismissed as **marginal** or **servile**. Grandma Lin taught engineering with **brusque** affection. Brandon taught law with older-brother patience and occasionally forgot not to be proud. Melissa taught escape routes, though the new assembly refused to make that an official subject. Grace, Ada, and Zoe helped new students find their places.

The city asked Stephanie to become First Keeper of the Prism. It was an **auspicious** honor, but it filled her with **trepidation**. Titles had a way of becoming cages. She did not want to become another **ostentatious** symbol while other people did the work.

She sought advice from Grandpa Bruce, who had regained enough strength to walk the river steps. He listened, then said, "Do not confuse humility with fear."

"That sounds like something Grandma Lin would say."

"She did. I improved it."

Stephanie laughed. "Should I accept?"

"Only if you can remain **resilient** when they praise you, **candid** when they question you, and **circumspect** when they offer easy power."

At the ceremony, she did accept, but with conditions. The Prism would belong to no single keeper. Its records would be public. Its mechanisms would be taught. No engineer would hold secret **hegemony** over the river again.

Some called her conditions **quixotic**. Others called them **pragmatic**. Stephanie called them necessary.

When the first free rain release began, blue light rose through the city. It touched roofs, cups, faces, and the restored Bell House. The image was **ephemeral**, almost **evanescent**, but what it revealed was lasting.

Melissa stood beside Stephanie, arms folded. "You realize they will ask for a speech."

"I know."

"Do you have one?"

"No."

"Excellent. Your terror will make it brief."

Stephanie stepped forward. Her knees were not **infallible**. Her voice was not grand. But it carried.

"We were told scarcity was natural," she said. "We were told truth was dangerous. We were told obedience was virtue. All of that was false. Today we do not **commemorate** a ruler. We **commemorate** a city that chose to see."

The crowd answered not with obedience, but with cups raised high.

Epilogue: The Common River

Years later, schoolchildren would read the story in a primer too tidy to be entirely true. It would smooth Melissa's temper, soften Grandma Lin's sarcasm, and make Brandon braver earlier than he had been. It would omit Yamin's complaints, Jimin's nightmares, and the many meetings where reform nearly died of boredom.

Stephanie did not mind. History always had a **propensity** to polish itself. That was why the archives mattered.

In the true records, the revolution was neither clean nor **imminent** from the beginning. It had been **wrought** by frightened people who became useful to one another. It had survived **tribulation**, **scrutiny**, **reproach**, and the **turbulent** work of trust. It had required not only courage but **sagacity**, not only anger but restraint.

The river did not make Ilyr perfect. No water could. There were still **disparate** factions, **capricious** elections, **mercurial** leaders, **inane** slogans, and a few **notorious** frauds who tried to sell bottled "original freedom water" to tourists. Melissa chased one of them into a canal and called the act civic education.

An **eccentric** guild of river guides formed soon after, claiming they could teach newcomers to **assimilate** into free Ilyr by rowing its canals at dawn. Their founder had an **elusive** smile, an **indelible** scar, and a **penchant** for speeches that began as wisdom and became weather reports. Stephanie found the guild mostly **superfluous**, but its **pastoral** songs built real **rapport** between old districts and new ones. That was no small thing. In a city once easy to **enervate** with fear, even a song could **impel** action, give **impetus** to repair crews, and keep a **precipitous** quarrel from becoming a riot. Melissa would still **accost** corrupt inspectors in public, and Brandon would still insist that one scandal could **mar** a fragile law, but the charter's **pinnacle** was this: no official could hide the river again.

But no child in Ilyr grew up believing thirst was fate.

On the fiftieth anniversary of the First Rain, an old Stephanie sat beneath the Great Prism while students gathered around her. One asked whether she had ever been certain they would **prevail**.

Stephanie considered giving a noble answer. Instead, she gave a true one.

"No. Most days I was terrified."

The student looked disappointed.

"Good," Stephanie said. "Remember that. Courage without fear is often just **hubris**. Courage with fear can still change the world."

Above them, riverlight bent through glass and scattered over the square, bright enough to make every face shine.

中文版：Stephanie and the Riverlight Edict

中文版用于帮助理解剧情；正式词汇学习以英文版为准。

第一章：玻璃之城

Ilyr城的雨不是从云里落下来的，而是由议会的玻璃高塔分配。Stephanie Venn在透镜大厅工作，她细心、好奇，也越来越怀疑那些关于“缺水”的官方说法。

很多年前，Stephanie的奶奶Grandma Lin和爷爷Grandpa Bruce教过她：光会暴露挡住它的那只手。她的哥哥Brandon、姐姐Melissa、爸爸Yamin、妈妈Jimin都知道，这个家族一直不相信议会。Stephanie的两个好朋友Grace和Ada也一直帮她保守秘密。

当Stephanie在透镜里看到一束不正常的蓝光时，她意识到城下可能有一条被隐藏的河。Melissa带来偷出的地图，Brandon用他的档案知识确认旧记录被篡改。三个人决定寻找证据。

第二章：钟屋

Stephanie、Melissa和Brandon沿着复杂的地下通道来到钟屋附近。他们在那里见到Grandma Lin。奶奶曾经是著名工程师，因为拒绝替议会撒谎，被当成异端。

Grandma Lin告诉他们，高塔并不制造水，只是控制水。真正的河流就在城下，足够养活所有人。可是高塔也支撑着城市，不能鲁莽摧毁。唯一安全的办法，是找到Prime Lens，在全城面前展示真相。

第三章：学者监狱

钟屋同时也是关押学者的监狱。Melissa说，妈妈Jimin被关在那里。Brandon伪造文件，Melissa带路，Stephanie用透镜打开封印。

他们找到Jimin，也找到虚弱的Grandpa Bruce。Jimin曾写文章嘲笑议会的假慈善，因此被关押。Grandpa Bruce把破裂的Prime Lens交给Stephanie，告诉她：议会最大的弱点是傲慢。

第四章：节日前的计划

Grandpa Bruce知道议会如何制造周期性的缺水，用痛苦控制人民。Stephanie修复Prime Lens，Brandon研究节日程序，Melissa负责行动路线。爸爸Yamin一开始很怀疑，认为大家只有勇气，没有计划，但当他看到地下河的影像时，也沉默了。

Grace和Ada作为Stephanie最好的朋友加入了计划。Grace在诊所照顾缺水的病人，Ada帮助联系旧井看守人。后来她们又认识了新朋友Zoe。Zoe熟悉运河区，能把消息传到普通人中间。

第五章：坏人Prince

坏人Prince是议会的统治者。他住在华丽宫殿里，懂得怎样用恐惧管理城市。他的调查官Malrec向他报告：Stephanie一家正在寻找河流的证据。

Prince不想立刻杀死他们，因为他害怕制造英雄。他命令Malrec把逮捕伪装成日常检查，让真相看起来像偶然的麻烦。他真正害怕的不是一副透镜，而是故事传播开来。

第六章：下城区

Stephanie和Melissa去下城区寻找证人。她们看到病人、干井、缺水的学校。Grace带她们进入诊所，Ada和Zoe帮助联系愿意作证的人。越来越多普通人加入：面包师、歌手、钟表匠、印刷工。

困难也越来越多。有人被抓，暗号出错，车辆坏掉。Melissa想用武力解决问题，Stephanie提醒她不能把每个问题都当成战斗。Yamin带来消息：Malrec已经搜查了Grandma Lin的工作室。时间不多了。

第七章：旧水厂

Prime Lens还缺一个银环，藏在旧水厂。那里充满蒸汽、塌陷的齿轮和危险通道。Stephanie靠河光辨认方向，Brandon记录墙上的旧文字，Melissa负责保护大家。

他们发现第一代工程师留下的警告：不要让任何权力独占公共的河。拿到银环后，Malrec包围了他们。关键时刻，Grandpa Bruce打开蒸汽阀，大家趁乱逃走。

第八章：没有真相的审判

Jimin为了掩护大家被抓。Prince把她带到大厅台阶上公开审判，想让她承认真相是假的。Jimin虽然受伤，却只说了一句：“Prince害怕水。”

这句话在人群中引起震动。Prince判她去劳役，想让同情变成恐惧。Stephanie很想立刻救妈妈，但Melissa提醒她，如果现在行动，整个计划都会失败。她们决定第二天在广场揭示地下河。

第九章：第一次雨的彩排

彩排那天，Prince站在高台上发表虚假的祝福。Stephanie爬进Great Prism塔，把Prime Lens和银环装好。Brandon用文书混乱拖住守卫，Melissa和Yamin制造烟雾引开巡逻。

阳光击中透镜，蓝色河光从广场升起。所有人都看见石板下真实流动的河。Stephanie通过号角说：河是真的，短缺是制造出来的。Grandpa Bruce、Brandon和Grace拿出证据，Prince的谎言开始崩塌。

第十章：Prince最后的手段

Prince不肯认输。他命令打开紧急水门，想制造洪水，让人民以为河流危险。Stephanie发现警报后，和Melissa、Grandpa Bruce、Yamin一起冲进控制坑。

水压巨大，阀门生锈。Yamin击中Stephanie指出的裂缝，压力开始下降。Malrec追来阻止他们，Melissa挡住他。最后Stephanie打开最后一道阀门，让河水进入城市水道，而不是毁掉城市。

第十一章：水之后

傍晚，干涸的广场有了喷泉，议会的权威开始崩塌。Prince被自己的守卫抓住，Malrec逃走。城市进入临时会议，所有人都争论如何补偿受害者、如何惩罚罪犯、如何公开档案。

Brandon提醒大家不要让复仇变成新的统治。Melissa要求坏官员负责。Grandma Lin坚持处罚必须符合证据。Grace提出给受害家庭补偿，Jimin要求把钟屋改成学校。Yamin起草了第一份公共宪章。

第十二章：透镜师的选择

几个月后，Stephanie回到透镜大厅。那里不再服务议会，而是向所有地区的孩子开放。Grandma Lin教工程，Brandon教法律，Melissa教逃生路线，Grace、Ada和Zoe帮助新的学生适应自由后的城市。

城市邀请Stephanie成为First Keeper of the Prism。她害怕头衔会变成新的牢笼，于是向Grandpa Bruce请教。爷爷告诉她：不要把谦逊和恐惧混在一起。Stephanie接受了职位，但要求所有记录公开、所有机械原理都被教学。

尾声：公共之河

多年后，学校会把这段历史写得更整齐、更简单。但Stephanie知道，真正的改变来自害怕却仍然互相信任的人。她的家人、朋友和新朋友Zoe一起证明了：真相不一定让世界完美，但能让人不再把口渴当作命运。

五十周年那天，年老的Stephanie坐在Great Prism下。一个学生问她当年是否确定会成功。她说：“不。大多数时候我都很害怕。”然后她补充：“记住，勇气不是没有恐惧；勇气是带着恐惧仍然去改变世界。”